



Prakash Mathema AFP/Getty Images

FLOODS DEVASTATE NEPAL

Rescuers aid a survivor on Wednesday. At least 160 people were killed, three of them in China. **WORLD, A3**

STATES
SUE USPS
OVER ITS
BALLOT
RULES

Filing argues mail-in voting changes amount to federal overreach and will expose data.

By Kevin Rector

California and other Democrat-led states sued again Wednesday to block the U.S. Postal Service from implementing new nationwide rules for mail ballots, arguing they usurp state authority over elections at President Trump's behest, expose voter information unnecessarily and threaten chaos in the rapidly approaching November election.

The Postal Service formally issued a 95-page "final rule" on Friday asserting that it was amending its mailing standards for mail ballots in federal elections to comply with Trump's March executive order.

Trump demanded the rule changes as part of a broader plan to combat what he alleges — without evidence — is widespread voter fraud in the U.S., including by noncitizens voting through the mail. Election experts say there is zero evidence of such problems existing in significant numbers.

"This mail-in voting rule is an unlawful overreach that shows just how far President Trump will go to control elections, but as I've said before, this fight is far from [See **Ballots**, A14]

Universities place own bets on new AI majors

Many campuses adapt curricula, citing demand

By Jaweed Kaleem

USC and UCLA are joining the rush to embed artificial intelligence and new digital technologies into college coursework as the academic year begins, announcing new AI majors and initiatives, betting that degrees built partly or entirely around AI will launch careers and pay off after graduation.

At USC, the Viterbi School of Engineering is launching its inaugural undergraduate artificial intelligence degree. The major is housed in the Mark and Mary Stevens School of Computing and Artificial Intelligence inside the engineering school. Students will spend four years learning to build the technology and to apply it to fields as far apart as drug discovery, robotics and agriculture.

In Westwood, UCLA is taking a different approach, opening what officials describe as the nation's first freestanding Department of Digital Humanities. A new bachelor's degree in digital human-

ities will teach students how to integrate AI and digital tools into disciplines including sociology, archaeology, history, and the study of race and gender.

These powerhouse Los Angeles institutions join a growing cohort of universities in California and nationwide responding quickly to a technology most undergraduates first encountered in chat bots or social media feeds in middle and high school.

Some campuses — including the new programs at USC and University of San Francisco — are teaching students to build the systems. Others are showing them how to study, and improve upon, what the technology can do for society. Nearly all are requiring ethics courses along the way — as educators continue to grapple with cheating and with fears that heavy AI use will erode critical thinking.

UC Santa Barbara is also launching an AI major this [See **AI**, A14]

Taking a danger off streets

Orange County, spurred by a rise in crashes by youths, will buy back e-bikes.

By Salvador Hernandez

You've heard of gun buyback programs across the country, but in Orange County, they've taken it one step further to get another item that authorities say can be a deadly weapon off the streets — the e-bike.

In September, the Orange County district attorney's office will host an e-bike buyback program, offering anywhere from \$200 to \$1,000 for each, no questions

asked.

The program, said the office in a statement, is patterned after police departments' gun buyback programs.

"These vehicles are not child's play, and the consequences are incredibly dangerous and increasingly deadly," Orange County Dist. Atty. Todd Spitzer said in a statement. "We are doing everything we can to protect and save lives."

"Buy back safety," reads a flier for the event.

The effort speaks to the increasingly stringent — and desperate — measures public agencies and lawmakers in California are attempting in order to stem a troubling rise in e-bike incidents. This summer has been marked by

police pursuits, street takeovers and fatal crashes that have claimed the lives of pedestrians and sent scores of riders to the emergency room.

E-bikes have become a California phenomenon for both adults and children. But officials are most concerned about young riders on the electric bicycles and motorcycles outfitted with the most powerful motors that can sometimes outrun police vehicles.

Those powerful bikes have been the focus of the most scrutiny. Earlier this summer, Amazon agreed to halt sales of high-speed e-bikes in California amid criticism from state officials. California law caps pedal- [See **E-bikes**, A7]

Meta agrees to settle teenage addiction claims

Social media giant would pay \$17 billion and add child-safety measures to platforms.

By Queenie Wong and Sonja Sharp

Meta Platforms agreed to pay up to \$17 billion and make changes to its social networks Facebook and Instagram as part of a landmark settlement to resolve a child-safety lawsuit that involved California and other states.

The proposed settlement, which still needs approval and would be the largest legal action against the tech titan, cuts short a high-profile trial that started a little more than a week ago in a federal court in California.

It's the latest example of how the world's largest social media company is grappling with legal challenges that seek to hold it account-

able, accusing the company of harming children.

California was among dozens of states that sued Meta in 2023, alleging in a lawsuit that the social media giant intentionally designed harmful and addictive features to hook children while misleading the public about the dangers. Some of the harms included depression, anxiety, addiction and body image issues as young people compare themselves with others on social media.

The states accused Meta of violating state consumer protection laws and a federal law that protects the online privacy of children younger than 13.

"This is momentous. This is a major step forward in the ongoing quest and journey to make sure that our children are safe everywhere, including online," said California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta in a news conference Wednesday morning.

As part of the proposed deal to settle claims filed by [See **Meta**, A10]



Genaro Molina Los Angeles Times

KOREATOWN tenant Joe Porter, right, is refusing to pay until he sees a clearer breakdown of utility costs.

Renters vexed by opaque utility bills

Confounded by rising shared costs, they're demanding third-party firms reveal the math.

By Audrey McGlinchy

Joe Porter toured the squat apartment building in L.A.'s Koreatown five years ago, excited to be leaving his parents' house in Arkansas. The rent on the studio was cheap — about \$1,500 a month — and the leasing agent, he said, told him he'd probably pay only an additional \$50 for utilities.

But three years after Porter moved in, his monthly bill for trash, sewer and water had more than doubled, to \$182 from \$86. He couldn't figure out why; water rates charged by the city utility had not increased at the same rate. When Porter

and his neighbors asked to see the math behind what they owed, the property management sent them a general overview of how the charges are calculated but did not provide copies of specific bills.

Unlike with traditional utility bills, Porter wasn't being billed by the provider but by a third-party company — Conserve, in this case — that uses what's called a ratio utility billing system. This means that the landlord does not charge each resident for their individual utility usage but sends them statements based on a formula applied to the building's total usage.

So Porter asked Conserve for a breakdown of his individual bill. "Can I please see the proof that this is money that I actually owe you and see how you got [to] it?" Porter recalled asking [See **Utilities**, A11]

Mexico confronts U.S. over deaths

President Sheinbaum vows to ramp up pressure to investigate the migrant fatalities. **PERSPECTIVES, A2**



Getty Images

VERSATILE
TIM CURRY
DIES AT 80

British actor played Dr. Frank-N-Furter in "Rocky Horror Picture Show" and voiced many roles. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

High-stakes bills face a deadline

With only days left in session, lawmakers are parsing dozens of energy and environmental priorities. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Walter's company decries 'attacks'

Dodgers owner's TWG Global rejects fraud allegations and reiterates the team is not for sale. **SPORTS, B10**

Weather

Partly sunny and hot. L.A. Basin: 96/75. **B6**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.



Overlooked autism takes a toll on girls

Delayed diagnosis is common, and poses a serious mental health risk

By Corinne Purtill



Arin Yoon For The Times

JESSICA Leffler holds a photo of her daughter, Ruby, who wasn't diagnosed with autism until she was 14.

reasons for the way she perceived things, words for the sensory experiences that set her apart from peers.

Leffler was angry. Why did Ruby have to go so many years without the support she needed? Why did none of the professionals the family asked for help identify her needs? Why did she spend the formative years of her life being treated by teachers and peers like a failure, instead of a person navigating a world designed for a different way of thinking?

And today, after Ruby's 2024 death by suicide at age 15, she wants to know: Why are so many autistic girls with gifts and challenges like Ruby being overlooked?

Autistic children are significantly more likely than their neurotypical peers to have co-occurring mental health conditions like depression and anxiety, and to [See **Autism**, A7]